bystanders. This was a point of no return. The population could no longer trust the military, which some had viewed as a protector of the state. The honor and prestige of the military was lost forever.

By mid August opposition was growing. Noncommunist groups were calling for an alliance with the student organizations. Several thousand students fled to the Thailand border to join with the insurgents. Unfortunately, fighting between insurgency factions broke out, making the development of a coherent strategy impossible. Second, the All-Burma Bar Council fell in line with the students, demanding an end to martial law and an opening of civil society in Burma. Most importantly, Aung San Suu Kyi sent a letter to the government asking for sincere mediation efforts between the state and the protesters.

Sein Lwin resigned the chairmanship of the BSPP in early August. Protesters clamored for his arrest, blaming him for the killings of March and May. Lwin who was known as “the butcher of Rangoon,” probably fled overseas. The student movement seemed to have won a major victory. The death toll at this point was over 3,000. The regime continued a policy of cover-up and denial. Martial law remained in place. The regime was weakening and at the party congress it was announced that a civilian, Dr. Maung Maung, was taking over the leadership helm. Maung, the attorney general at the time, would be the first civilian leader in Burma's history.

During August, several urban areas including Rangoon came under the control of the protesters. The antigovernment opposition now included a sizeable number of workers as well as a growing number of monks. Maung Maung was considered an unacceptable replacement leader. Maung was thought of as a puppet of former leader Ne Win. The opposition wanted Maung to resign by September 7. Concessions followed with the releasing of prominent leaders such as Aung Gyi as well as the lifting of martial law. Finally, Maung promised a second BSPP congress to decide on a referendum for free and fair elections. To help guide the process, the BSPP formed an election commission to oversee the transition.

During this tension-filled month, the tatmadaw remained mostly out of sight. The state continued to decline with the economy in a free fall and public facilities nonfunctioning and strikes commonplace. The population enjoyed a greater degree of freedom than anytime in Burmese history as